Get the Family Ready to Compare Care Options for Your Wife Fairly

Four prompts to agree the criteria before the argument, separate what you saw from what you were told, keep the open questions visible, and prepare for a family conversation that can end in a decision.

Where you are

Your wife has to move to a new care arrangement soon, and you've toured or called a few places. One felt right. Your daughter prefers another. Everyone has an opinion, and nobody has written down what you're actually comparing against.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can walk into the family conversation with the same criteria for every option, a clear list of what's confirmed and what isn't, and the questions still to put to a provider or a professional before anyone signs anything.

A one-page Decision Prep Sheet: Our criteria, What we've confirmed, What's still open, Who needs to be in the conversation, and Questions for the next tour or call.

Before you start

- What your wife needs help with now, from the hospital, the care team, or your own notes.
- Your notes from any tours or calls, however messy.
- What your wife has said she wants, if she's able to say. Half of these is enough to start.

PROMPT 1

Agree the criteria before anyone argues

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families fight about places when they haven't agreed what matters. A written list of essentials and preferences, made before the comparison, gives everyone the same ruler.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your wife's current needs and what she and the family care about.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is what my wife needs help with now, and what she and our family care about in where she lives:

> [PASTE HER NEEDS]
>
> [PASTE WHAT SHE AND THE FAMILY CARE ABOUT]
>
> Sort everything into three lists: ESSENTIAL (any option that can't do this is out, whatever else it offers), STRONGLY PREFERRED, and NICE TO HAVE. Where my wife herself said something, mark it with her initial so it stays visible. Flag anything in the ESSENTIAL list that a clinician would need to confirm rather than the family. Do not mention or evaluate any specific option, and leave an item where I've clearly placed it myself.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

An essentials list short enough to use on every option without arguing about it.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the three lists to everyone who'll be in the conversation, and ask only whether anything is missing.

PROMPT 2

Separate what you saw from what you were told from how it felt

WHY THIS MATTERS

A tour mixes three things: what you watched happen, what a staff member said, and the feeling you left with. All three matter. Only the first two can be checked.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes from one tour or call at a time, with the provider's name replaced by a letter.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my notes from a visit or call about one possible option for my wife. I've called it Option [LETTER]:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES FOR ONE OPTION]
>
> Sort every line into three columns: WHAT I SAW OR HEARD HAPPEN, WHAT STAFF TOLD ME, and HOW IT FELT. Then, against each ESSENTIAL item below, note whether this visit gave me an observation, a statement, nothing, or just a feeling:
>
> [PASTE YOUR ESSENTIAL LIST]

> Do not score this option, say whether it is good or bad, or compare it to anything. I'll run this once per option.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Essentials where all you have is a feeling or a staff statement.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Repeat the prompt for each option you've visited or called.

PROMPT 3

Keep the open questions visible

WHY THIS MATTERS

Once one option feels appealing, the unanswered questions start to feel answered. Listing them, with who has to answer each, keeps them alive until someone actually does.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The sorted notes from Prompt 2 for every option, and your essentials list.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here are my sorted notes for each option we're considering for my wife, and our essentials list:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPT 2 FOR EACH OPTION]
>
> [PASTE THE ESSENTIAL LIST]
>
> List every essential that is still unconfirmed for any option, one line per item per option, with: WHAT WE STILL NEED TO KNOW, WHO CAN ANSWER IT (the provider, her doctor or nurse, a care consultant, the family, or my wife herself), and HOW (a call, a tour question, a document, a conversation). Then add questions about what happens if her needs increase. Do not answer any of them, and do not rank the options by how many questions remain.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The items only a provider or a clinician can close. Those gate the decision.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Make the calls or ask the questions that close the biggest items this week.

PROMPT 4

Prepare the family conversation

WHY THIS MATTERS

You're not writing the decision yet. You're writing the page that lets the family make it together: the criteria, the facts, what's still open, who needs to be present, and what to ask next.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from Prompts 1 to 3, and a list of who in the family is involved.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything my family has gathered about my wife's care options, and who in the family is involved:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> [PASTE WHO IS INVOLVED AND HOW]
>
> Write a one-page Decision Prep Sheet with five headings: OUR CRITERIA, WHAT WE'VE CONFIRMED (observations and provider statements, kept separate), WHAT'S STILL OPEN, WHO NEEDS TO BE IN THE CONVERSATION, and QUESTIONS FOR THE NEXT TOUR OR CALL. Under WHO NEEDS TO BE IN THE CONVERSATION, list the people I've named and include my wife herself. Do not say who has legal authority to decide, do not recommend, rank, or score any option, and do not resolve any disagreement I've described.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page the relative who disagrees with you could read and accept as fair.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share it a day before the conversation so nobody reads it for the first time in the room.

Comparison starts with her needs written down

The criteria you're about to agree on come from what your wife needs and wants. The care interview records that as a Family Care Profile, and it's the file your care consultant reads before she helps the family compare what's really on the table.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›